Disproportionate arrest rates for blacks, especially for young black men, make revolutionary Cuba look much like the United States and Brazil and seem to undermine the Revolution's claims to have eliminated racial inequality. De la Fuente suggests two ways of explaining the apparent contradictions. One, structural changes that have reduced socioeconomic inequality do not necessarily or immediately bring about corresponding shifts in social attitudes. Deeply imbedded cultural beliefs about race may be more resistant to change than are infant mortality rates and economic and educational opportunity. Or they might require different kinds of methods for change.

Second, he notes that despite increased economic opportunity for blacks in many areas, the historical legacy of residential segregation was not overcome. Thus "the chance for young blacks to grow up in these poorer areas remained significantly greater than for whites. Likewise, the chances for young blacks to be socialized in what Cuban criminologists referred to as the criminal micro-environment were also significantly larger."[14]

The second conclusion is in some ways the more optimistic of the two. It suggests that government spending and activism can indeed bring about fundamental social change even in such apparently obstinate social areas like racial inequality. The former possibility, that racial attitudes are durable even in the face of structural change, offers a less hopeful vision for the possibilities of social change. History does not offer us many counter-examples.

Other authors – Carlos Moore and Mark Q. Sawyer, in particular – offer an even more pessimistic account. Cuban exile Carlos Moore complained of Fidel Castro's "icy silence on anything remotely touching the plight of Black Cuba."[15] Both authors argue that an attempt to privilege nationality and class, to disdain racial consciousness and to avoid directly confronting racism per se characterized the Cuban Revolution and limited its ability to shake the country's racial divisions. Sawyer calls Cuba's racial ideology one of "inclusionary discrimination" that "encourages the ongoing marginalization of Afro-Cubans in Cuban social, economic and political life."[16] As in the early